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4. Use of 'ie' and 'ei'

a) When 'ie' or 'ei' is pronounced like 'ee' in 'bee', 'i' comes before 'e' except after 'c'.

e.g. 'ie' – field / achieve / believe
'ei' after 'c' – receive / deceive / receipt / deceit

(Note some exceptions: seize / surfeit / protein)

b) This rule does not apply to those words, where the two vowels 'ei' are not pronounced like 'ee' as in 'bee'.

e.g. height / weight / neighbour / leisure / fiery / friend

5. Use of 'oi' and 'oy'

'oi' is used in the middle of a word and 'oy' is used at the end of a word.

e.g. turmoil, soil, boil / destroy, boy, toy

6. Use of 'ou' and 'ow'

'ou' is used in the middle of a word, whereas 'ow' is used at the end of words, except those that end in letter 'n' or letter 'd'.

e.g. blouse, mount, found / borrow, sorrow

7. Confusing endings

-our, -or, -ar, -er, -re, -able, -ible, -ent, -ant, -ence, -ance, -ceed, -cede are often confusing because there are no rules to decide when to use one or another. We should learn them only through familiarity and by use.

Here is a list of some words with each of these endings. You can recall and add a few more.

-ar – beggar, burglar, circular, grammar, particular, popular, regular, scholar, secular

-er – adviser, beginner, courier, deliver, explorer, gardener, lecturer, manager, observer, promoter

-or - ancestor, bachelor, corridor, director, equator, governor, instructor, monitor, operator, traitor

-our – behaviour, endeavour, flavour, rumour, splendour

-re – agriculture, atmosphere, literature, millionaire, pressure, temperature, questionnaire

-able – acceptable, bearable, comfortable, durable, profitable, respectable, valuable, workable

-ible – audible, compatible, divisible, eligible, horrible, possible, responsible, sensible, terrible

-ent – adjacent, confident, different, excellent, obedient, intelligent, permanent, resident, sufficient

-ant – assistant, brilliant, dominant, elegant, ignorant, important, pleasant, reluctant, triumphant

-ceed – exceed, proceed, succeed

-cede – accede, concede, precede, recede

-sede – supersede (Note: This is the only word that ends with –sede)

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